



Do I Need a Utility Search?

A free LSBUD Insight guide to help householders, contractors, designers, managers and site teams decide when a utility search should be considered before ground is disturbed.

Core message

If the job breaks, penetrates, drills, drives, trenches, excavates or disturbs the ground, buried services should be considered.

1

Will ground be disturbed?

2

Could services be present?

3

Is uncertainty material?

4

Choose the route

Use this guide to: recognise when a utility search is likely to be relevant, understand what a search can and cannot do, and decide when to escalate to Top-Up, survey, report or Pro/account routes.

Important: this guide is a decision aid, not legal advice or a substitute for current HSE guidance, competent advice, asset owner instructions or site-specific assessment.

1. The short answer

A utility search should be considered whenever work could disturb the ground and there is a possibility that underground services, service connections, ducts, cables, pipes, drains or private assets may be present.

HSE's HSG47 guidance is aimed at those involved in commissioning, planning, managing and carrying out work on or near underground services, and it explains a safe system of work through planning the work, locating and identifying buried services, and safe excavation.

Plain-English rule

If the work creates a hole, trench, post hole, excavation, duct route, anchor point or ground penetration, ask: what could be below?

A search is not only for large construction schemes. Small works can still hit shallow or private services, particularly around boundaries, driveways, gardens, footways, lighting columns, gates, outbuildings and service entries.

A search also does not make excavation safe on its own. Plans and records help you plan. They do not prove exact position, depth, condition, private ownership or every unrecorded route.

2. Quick decision checklist

If any answer is “yes” or “not sure”, the work should usually move into a safe digging decision process. That may mean a OneCall Utility Search, further site checks, survey, Top-Up or a competent review.

Question	Yes / not sure means...	Likely next step
Will the ground be broken, drilled, driven, excavated, trenched or penetrated?	Buried services may be encountered, even on domestic or small works.	Consider OneCall Utility Search.
Is the work near a building, boundary, road, footway, cabinet, chamber, meter, lighting column or service entry?	Service connections and shallow assets may be present.	Search plus local checks; consider Top-Up or survey if unclear.
Could the work affect drainage, watercourses, ditches, sewers or land drains?	Drainage and environmental constraints may be relevant.	Consider OneCall plus Open Water / Environmental Constraints where site-specific.
Is the work part of a C2, tender, design, planning, development or evidence pack?	Search quality, audit trail and response completeness matter.	OneCall, Top-Up or Comprehensive Premium.
Would a strike cause injury, outage, programme delay, environmental harm or cost escalation?	Higher consequence requires stronger controls.	Search plus PAS128/GPR or competent review.

3. Common activities where a search is often relevant

Activity	Why services may be present	Typical recommendation
Fencing, gates and post holes	Boundary areas often contain shallow service connections, lighting, private cables, old ducts and supplies to outbuildings.	Fencing guidance, Service Connection Risk Guide, OneCall Utility Search, Select Surveys if uncertainty remains.
Extensions, foundations and driveways	Works often cross private supplies, drainage, water, telecoms, electricity or gas service routes into the property.	Householder checklist, OneCall Utility Search, Top-Up where private/unknown service risk remains.
Groundworks and civils	Excavation depth, plant, programme pressure and utility density increase consequence and uncertainty.	OneCall Utility Search, PAS128/GPR Survey Quote, Vacuum Excavation Request where appropriate.
Highways, footways and street furniture	Highway corridors can contain dense networks of utilities and ducts.	OneCall, Highways guidance, PAS128/GPR, Comprehensive Premium for complex schemes.
Drainage, ditches and watercourses	Utilities, sewers, drainage, environmental constraints and open water risks may overlap.	OneCall plus Open Water Proximity or Environmental Constraints where relevant.
Design, planning and C2 packs	Decisions depend on evidence and early risk visibility, not only the final excavation method.	OneCall Core, Top-Up, Comprehensive Premium, history and resubmit workflows.

4. What a utility search can and cannot do

A utility search is a planning control. It helps create a picture of known or supplied asset information for a defined area. It should be used alongside site records, visual checks, competent locating methods, trial holes and safe excavation practice.

A utility search helps you...	A utility search does not automatically...
Identify relevant utility owners or asset information for the defined area.	Guarantee exact position, depth, condition or completeness of all underground services.
Plan works, brief teams and decide if more checks are needed.	Replace a site-specific risk assessment, safe system of work or competent supervision.
Support C2 packs, tender packs, design reviews and project evidence.	Confirm every private, abandoned, historic, unrecorded or recently installed service.
Trigger better questions about Top-Up, PAS128/GPR, Open Water, Environmental Constraints or Large Site needs.	Mean it is safe to dig without locating, marking, exposing and protecting services.

Avoid false confidence

The right question is not only “do I have plans?”; it is “is the information good enough for this work, this place and this risk?”

5. Choosing the right LSBUD Insight route

Need	Recommended route	Access mode
I only need simple advice	Read Library guidance, FAQs and Wiki entries such as Safe Digging Essentials, Service Connection Risk Guide and Utility Plans Explained.	Guest
I am planning ground disturbance	Start OneCall Utility Search for the defined area, then use the results as part of broader safe digging controls.	Login for submission
I need wider evidence or missing coverage	Consider Top-Up Search or Comprehensive Premium Search.	Login / Pro
I need to know where utilities actually are	Consider Select Surveys Quote Request, PAS128 / GPR Survey Quote or other detection/verification options.	Login for quote
My site is large, linear or complex	Use Large Site Search or Comprehensive Premium route.	Login / Pro
I need watercourse or environmental context	Use Open Water Proximity Risk Report or Environmental Constraints Report alongside utility search where works are planned.	Login for report
I manage repeat works or teams	Consider Pro Account, saved history, training, included service bundles and team workflows.	Pro

6. Persona examples

The same activity may need a different call to action depending on who is asking. LSBUD Insight uses persona and intent to recommend the first sensible step.

Persona	Likely concern	First recommendations
Householder	Simple reassurance before a garden, driveway, fence or extension project.	Householder checklist, Do I Need a Utility Search?, OneCall if ground disturbance is planned.
Fencing contractor	Shallow service connections and boundary risks.	Fencing guidance, Service Connection Risk Guide, OneCall and survey quote if uncertain.
C2 pack collator	Evidence, completeness, expiry dates and repeat submissions.	OneCall, Top-Up, Comprehensive Premium, history and 28-day reminder.
Architect / designer	Early risk visibility before design or planning decisions harden.	Planning resource pack, Utility Plans Explained, OneCall, Select Surveys or Environmental Constraints.
Ecologist / environmental consultant	Watercourse, drainage or site constraint risk, sometimes before utility search is the priority.	Open Water guidance, Environmental Constraints, OneCall if works are planned.
Senior manager	Risk governance, repeat work, procurement and service strategy.	Executive briefing, Pro Account, premium services, Select Surveys or vacuum excavation routes.

7. Pre-search information checklist

Good search and report outputs depend on good input. Before starting a OneCall or related service route, gather as much of the following as possible.

Information	Why it helps	Ready?
Clear site location	Improves precision and reduces ambiguity in search, report or quote routing.	■
Work description	Helps choose enquiry type, work category and work type.	■
Work area boundary or route	Defines the geography for search, Large Site, Open Water or survey quoting.	■
Depth and method	Affects risk level and whether survey or vacuum excavation may be appropriate.	■
Dates and programme	Supports planning, resubmission and 28-day reminder logic.	■
Known site records	Private services, estate drawings and previous works can reveal assets missing from standard records.	■
Consequence of error	Higher consequence should increase the level of checking and escalation.	■

Practical prompt

If you cannot define the location, activity or work boundary clearly, pause before submitting and improve the brief.

Sources and limitations

This guide is original LSBUD Insight library content. It is designed as a public-facing decision aid to help users decide whether a utility search should be considered. It does not reproduce HSG47 or any third-party guidance in full.

Source	How it informed this guide
Health and Safety Executive, HSG47: Avoiding danger from underground services, Third edition, 2014.	Used as the key reference for the audience of safe digging guidance and for the three safe-system elements: planning the work, locating and identifying buried services, and safe excavation.
Health and Safety Executive, Excavation and underground services.	Used to support the emphasis on managing excavation risks, obtaining plans or suitable information, and taking precautions before disturbing the ground.
LSBUD Insight Persona Engine and Library Catalogue.	Used to align the guide with the planned Library and recommendation pathways for OneCall, Top-Up, Select Surveys/PAS128, Open Water, Environmental Constraints, Large Site and Pro account.

Limitations: this document is general guidance only. Users must consider legal duties, client requirements, CDM duties where relevant, current HSE guidance, asset owner instructions, site-specific hazards, competent advice and local procedures.

Recommended action: if works may disturb the ground, use the LSBUD Insight Hub to access relevant Library content and consider OneCall Utility Search or another recommendation route suited to the activity and site.